

Religion and the History of Hip Hop Final Assignment

Due Date: Wednesday, May 6, 2026, by 11:59 pm ET (via Courseworks)

Students may choose between the following two options as the culminating assignment for our work together this semester:

Option 1: Final Project (this project may be completed either individually or in a group)

1. Short Introductory Framing Paper: Write a 5-6 page essay that draws on readings from the semester to introduce your topic, outline your argument/thesis, and provide a context for the sources that you have collected in your Portfolio

NOTE: For group projects, each individual student will still be required to submit their own framing paper. If you are an individual working in a group, your framing paper should also address your particular contributions to the group portfolio.

2. Portfolio (with 8-10 annotated sources for individual projects / 15-20 annotated sources for groups): Collect 8-10 / 15-20 “primary sources” that document your proposed topic. Sources collected in a portfolio can include songs, videos, media coverage (i.e., newspaper or magazine stories), etc. Each source should be accompanied by a brief note (2-3 sentences) that helps to explain its significance for the topic at hand. (i.e., Who, what, where, when, why, and how).

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Option 2: Research Paper (ca. 10 double-spaced pages): Students may write a short research paper (on a topic of their choosing) that engages with reading materials assigned over the course of the semester and the music and culture that comprises the history of hip-hop to put forward an argument about the selected topic.

Guiding Criteria (for both options): Every Culminating Assignment (Final Projects and Final Papers) should be able to check off all of the following criteria:

_____ My paper/project explores the intersection of Hip Hop and Religion

_____ My paper/project engages at least three different artists/groups/albums or, if I opted to focus on a single artist/group, I engage at least three different albums by the chosen artist).

_____ My paper/project examines at least three decades (between the 1970s and the 2010s)

_____ My paper/project analyzes specific songs, albums, videos, etc.

_____ My paper/project locates the artist(s) and sources engaged in the paper/project within their broader social world and historical context (i.e. What do these artists/songs/albums tell us about the 1980s?)